

Photographs by MR NANDAKUMAR



allegations from the Opposition. "Though the Government had some flaws, they got magnified because the chief minister failed to put up a good defence and acted as a power unto himself," says a leader. To "bring the chief minister in line" with the party, it was decided that a set of guidelines would be formulated for better conduct of the 20-month-old Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government. "I accept all the criticism. I promise to correct all mistakes and go forward," said the beleaguered chief minister later at the rally. Though Achuthanandan was chastised and tamed at the conference, a complete decimation of his camp was averted thanks to the presence of the Politburo members. None from the VS camp, who was in the previous state committee, was excluded from the new committee.

It is clear that the factional war in CPI(M) has been behind many goof-ups of the Government. Various infrastructure development projects in the state are stuck because a pro-reform Vijayan camp and the orthodox chief minister could not reach a consensus on availing a Rs 1,200-crore loan from the Asian Development Bank. The Government's image suffered a major blow when the state's much-lauded

LULL BEFORE STORM: Karat addresses state meet in Kottayam

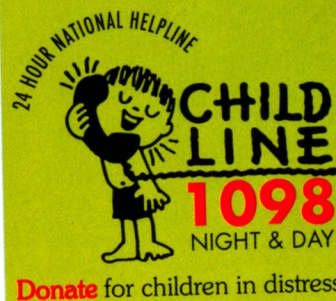
public health system collapsed and there was a repeated outbreak of chikungunia, which killed more than 250 people in two years. The delegates alleged that Achuthanandan did not lead from the front during that crisis because Health Minister P.K. Sreemathi belonged to his rival camp. Achuthanandan's much trumpeted but aborted move against land encroachers in Munnar also came in for attack as an "unplanned adventure done without consultations with the party".

Factionalism in the CPI(M)'s Kerala unit reached an unprecedented climax last year when both Achuthanandan and Vijayan were suspended from the Politburo for four months after they washed dirty linen in public. Now the rival camps claim that factionalism has come to an end and that the Government would learn from its mistakes to perform better. The guidelines proposed at the conference are expected to lift the Government out of the abyss. But if it is intended only to tame the chief minister, precious little can be expected from it. With the Lok Sabha polls due next year, the first acid test for the party is just round the corner. ■

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